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themes of the Manmohan legacy. And this prime minister is playing, in subdued steps certainly, to an appreciative global gallery, and his signature tunes are pro-Americanism and market liberalism. Still not a natural politician, Manmohan has turned this perceived inadequacy into an advantage. Instead of getting bogged down in realpolitik, he can play out the script of the statesman at a time when the world is short of such reassuring leaders with a global appeal. The Manmohan team reflects his mind. It consists of old loyalists (like Principal Secretary TKA Nair) and policy mavens who share his international and economic vision (like National Security Adviser Shiv Shankar Menon, planning czar Montek Singh Ahluwalia

EVERY PMO MIRRORS THE PERSONALITY of the PM—not only his priority as a policy-maker but his fears, paranoia and, of course, his dream.

and Economic Adviser C. Rangarajan). For political input, he has his favourites to depend on: Pranab Mukherjee and Sharad Pawar, two war horses who have never undermined the authority of the politically “inexperienced” prime minister. The quiet authority of this prime minister is a far cry from the 2004 image of the lucky but tentative new occupant of 7 Race Course Road.

The transformation tells the evolutionary story of the PMO as a supra-governmental power centre. India's first prime minister was not a great believer in a kitchen cabinet or in a secretariat of experts for the simple reason that Nehru himself was such a formidable brain that he hardly needed borrowed ones. His personal staff never enjoyed super-bureaucratic powers. A bureaucrat who worked in the Nehru government once told me:

“Since Nehru himself was well informed, he didn't require any expert advice from bureaucrats. He briefed bureaucrats instead of being briefed by them.” It was during the Indira Gandhi era that the Prime Minister's Men (yes, always men) acquired that shadowy, omnipotent status, and Lohia's dumb doll needed a private army to defeat the foxy gang of old men called the Syndicate. P.N. Dhar was the first principal secretary to the prime minister, and names like P.C. Alexander, H.Y. Sharada Prasad, Arjun Sengupta, Chinmaya Gharekhan, R.K. Dhawan and M.L. Fotedar would become the scriptwriters of the Indira legacy. When Rajiv Gandhi romanced India with his 21st century dream, he too had his band of the faithful, most of them his school buddies—and that was the time when Delhi became the site of a new Camelot.

There was no dilution of the powers of the PMO during the Narasimha Rao regime too. If principal secretary A.N. Verma was his indispensable counsellor, a handful of cabinet colleagues like Manmohan and S.B. Chavan were the trusted implementers of the Rao doctrine. Still, it was during the first right wing government that the supremacy of the PMO began to rhyme with the power of one individual: prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee's principal secretary-cum-NSA, Brajesh Mishra. Vajpayee was not the singular centre of political power while BJP was in power, but that didn't diminish his power as prime minister: it remained unchallenged, for none was worthier or popular than him. With Mishra as his non-political alter ego and Cabinet colleagues like Pramod Mahajan and Jaswant Singh as his political lieutenants, India's most popular prime minister from outside the dynasty too sanctified the power prerogatives of the prime minister.

Today, as Manmohan quite understandably seeks a place in the history of the subcontinent as a moderniser who took India to the frontline of global power, it is those chosen few who fine-tune the script. Their power is manifested in their master's glory. ■